

Taste of pain (bitter version)

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Taste of pain (bitter version)

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Summary

When the bond between you and your soulmate solidifies, you start to taste what they're eating.

Tim has been trying to figure his soulmate out forever now.

In Jason's books, having a soulmate is a hassle more than anything.

Notes

I had this idea lying around and decided to finalize it in an effort to get my writing mojo back.

This is what happens when the initial campfire steers wildly into angst territory.

See the end of the work for [more notes](#)

When the bond between you and your soulmate solidifies, you start to taste what they're eating.

Usually, people use that to try to communicate somehow — telegraph who they are or at least which part of the world they're from by eating ethnic and local dishes. It helps to narrow down the possibilities, and folks tend to be rather keen on finding their "other half".

Tim has been trying to figure his soulmate out forever now. One of his clearest childhood memories is the stark contrast of flavours in his mouth: between the restaurants his parents took him to and the cheap street food of his soulmate, between his freshly-steamed veggies from Mrs. Mac and the stale bread on the other side, between his dessert and their cruddy gas station candy.

So far, he knows quite a lot, given his limited information. He is sure his soulmate lives in roughly the same timezone as him, and judging by the general flavour profile and their usual foods, they're probably in the USA. Separately, tater tots, Velveeta cheese, or sloppy joes could be eaten anywhere by anyone, but all of them in this frequency? Has to be an American. The rate of New York-style pizza to any other kind suggests they might very well be living in New Jersey, too. His own state.

So close, yet so far away.

Yet, despite not having much to show for himself yet, Tim's determined to find them and knows he *can*. He figured Batman out, after all, didn't he?

In Jason's books, having a soulmate is a hassle more than anything. The tastes come uninvited and confusing, and there's always a sense of... invasion of your privacy when you remember someone else knows what and when you're eating.

But he'd be willing to ignore it and carry on with his life if it wasn't so goddamn annoying. Jason hates his soulmate, honestly.

It's a weird thing to do, but he seriously can't feel anything else. He doesn't tell anyone, of course, but he's pretty sure nobody would blame him anyway, if they knew what it was like. Because while he has to fight for every scrap he can find — just like everyone else in the Narrows — his soulmate is *well-fed*. And honestly, there's nothing worse than stomach pains from not having eaten in three days while you taste balanced meals, posh desserts, and hot cocoa on your tongue *all the time*. It's an insult to injury, that's what it is.

He can't even ignore it. It's there, in the back of his mouth, every day like clockwork. Fancy, warm, and tasty. It makes him think of the better days of his childhood, days long gone. Mom's food never was quite *this* flavorful, but it was better than the bruised fruit and squashed sandwiches he fishes out of the dumpsters these days. The taste of his soulmate's food is a painful reminder of things Jason has irreversibly lost.

And Jason hates his soulmate for that.

Tim spends a lot of time doing his hobbies: countless days stalking his soulmate, and countless nights stalking Batman and Robin.

One night, his hobbies overlap.

At first, he's convinced that he's dreaming. What's happening can't possibly be real. But then he loses his balance and falls flat on his ass; it *hurts*, so he has to reconcile with reality.

He looks back through the zoom in his camera to make sure he isn't simply imagining things, but no. That definitely is Robin sitting on a rooftop with Batman, eating a chilli dog from a local joint.

And Tim can taste *every. Single. Bite.*

He blinks slowly and swallows his saliva.

Well. That- ... that makes it easier. It also explains a lot. He knows the story (at least the one published in newspapers) of Jason Todd — Bruce Wayne's latest foster kid — and it would check out with his soulmate's diet through the years.

Huh. Well. Time to figure out how to drop that news on them, then? But it's... it's Jason Todd. It's *Robin*. And *Batman*. So far, Tim couldn't even bring himself to approach them to ask for an autograph. He's not sure he's brave enough to go and tell Jason he's his soulmate.

Tim tries to talk with Jason on several occasions and almost does it during one gala, but ultimately chickens out every time. He just can't find the right words and slinks away before Jason can figure out he's been up to something.

Jason doesn't seem interested in figuring out their bond, after all, so who is Tim to impose like that?

Eventually, he accepts it — grows accustomed to looking at Robin wistfully from afar, taking pictures and imagining. He's not from their world, he's not strong and brave and bold. All he can do is make sure he doesn't eat anything nasty, and worry over the occasional phantom taste of dust and blood in his mouth at night. So long there's always the post-patrol water to wash it out, he knows everything's fine. And, who knows, maybe one day Jason himself will change his mind and try to find him?

Then one night, there's more blood than usual, and dust more bitter than he's used to, and soon he knows what happened. He knows, because those are the last things he tastes from Jason.

There is no precedent and Tim is pretty sure he's not going to set one, either.

You only get one try at the soulmate thing. Once you lose them, they're gone. So why, *why the hell* is he tasting phantom flavours again?

When he wakes up with the sensation of dirt in his mouth, he assumes it's just dehydration.

When he starts tasting grainy, watery porridge out of the blue, he figures he must be hallucinating from exhaustion.

When he feels the vaguely familiar grease of street food and well-done burgers on his tongue, he guesses that it's his brain trying to comfort him by reminiscing about Jason. He is overworked and stressed most of the time, after all.

But it happens too often, too regularly, and there are flavours he's never experienced before, and— there's only one logical conclusion.

Jason is alive.

It must be a wild ride for the other party and Jason kind of pities them. If it's the same person as before — he's not sure if one can change soulmates? But you shouldn't be able to *come back to life*, either, so who knows — it must be very confusing to get phantom flavours again after all this time. Especially when he's pretty sure the first thing in his mouth after he came back was mud.

And if it's a new person? Well, he hopes it's a late bloomer and he didn't get paired up with a toddler. Knowing his luck, though, he probably was.

Either way, he's not going to really investigate the bond. He didn't have the time to do it back in the day, and he sure as hell doesn't have time now. His life never was about what he wants. Only about what needs to be done. About what the world throws at him. Maybe later, when Batman and Gotham's been dealt with, he'll allow himself to do something for himself for once in his life.

Maybe one day, he'll track them down and introduce himself. Apologise for all the gunpowder he's inhaled, question the inhuman quantities of coffee at ass o'clock that he tastes in return, and ask them out on a date. Maybe one day, he'll get to live properly.

But not today.

Today is dedicated to revenge, and to blood.

It is a dark, rainy night when Red Hood strikes the Titan Tower.

Tim takes the first hit like a champ, but there's just too much power behind the punch for him to keep his balance. He stumbles back, feeling his lip burst under the impact.

Hood stops, confused, for a brief moment. He clicks his tongue, tasting the metallic flavour suddenly in his mouth.

Tim taps his bloodied chin to give him a hint.

“No,” Jason whispers. “It can’t-”

“Yeah,” Tim sighs. “What a coincidence, huh? After all these years, you finally realise it too.”

Jay narrows his eyes, bristling at the bile in Tim’s voice. “You *knew*?”

“Since we were kids,” Tim says, straightening up, the words slightly slurred by his rapidly swelling lip. “Didn’t have the chance to say anything before you—” he trails off, making a vague gesture instead of saying *before you died*.

“And you haven’t bothered to tell anybody that you can taste me again?” Jason hisses out.

Tim lets out a bitter laugh. “Oh, I *did*. But nobody would believe me. I was trying to find you on my own, but you’re damn good at hiding, you know?”

Jason stays silent for a while, his head spinning. This... complicates everything. It shouldn’t, it shouldn’t really matter, but it *does*, and Jason didn’t think that fate could be *this* cruel.

“What do you plan to do now that you know I’m the Red Hood?”

Tim squints in suspicion. It sounds like... like an olive branch of sorts? It’s way less vengeful than he expected after, well, *everything* that Jason had done so far. It can’t be... real. He knows better than to take bait that is this obvious, so he deflects.

“That entirely depends on you. Do you still want to bleed the next Robin out?”

It’s a bullseye, because Jason drops the facade right away.

“You *replaced* me. You took my place and my family. That- that’s even *more* fucked up if you knew I’m your soulmate.”

“I tried to mourn losing my chance to meet you by being close to what was left of you, Jason. *You’re* the one who came here to murder a random kid.”

Jason sneers at the call-out. “Well, congratulations, you’re soulmates with a zombie murderer. Not what you hoped for, huh?”

“I was hoping that life would give us another chance,” Tim admits. “But it gave me a soulmate that punched me in the face as hello.”

“I guess we’re both unlucky motherfuckers, then.”

Tim takes a battle stance again, twirling his staff. “They say ‘*Till death do us part*’. I suppose it means we’re technically not mates anymore, then.”

“It seems so.”

They both taste warm blood that night. They both dream of what would happen if they’d been a little more willing to forgive, a little more willing to reach out.

End Notes

Big thanks to Jei and Jade for the beta-reading!

Please [drop by the Archive and comment](#) to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!